

Congregation Start Checklist

Evidence-backed working aid. Current official direction and original documents remain authoritative.

Official start: 2026-11-01 · **Congregation:** 3814 · **Circuit:** NZ-2

Legal and banking control: Do not independently create a charitable trust, register a charity, obtain a new IRD number, or open an account under an assumed entity. First obtain written direction from the branch Accounting/Legal function identifying the legal entity, official account name, tax/charity identifiers, governing documents and authorised banking process for congregation 3814.

The short version

Before 1 November, complete the announcement, leadership, JW Hub, accounting, shared-hall, meeting and ministry setup. On or shortly after 1 November, transfer people and records, confirm pioneers and appointed brothers, and begin congregation records. After November, submit the first field service report and operate the monthly accounting and compliance routines. Charity registration is conditional on branch direction; bank-account preparation may begin now, but the legal account holder must be confirmed first.

Use the persistent master checklist to tick these tasks and save notes. This page is the meeting-friendly launch view; the branch letter and current official direction remain controlling.

Launch gates

Gate	Meaning
Branch Required	Explicitly required by the approval letter or another cited official instruction.
Operational Readiness	Needed so the congregation can function cleanly from the start, even if the approval letter does not list it.
Confirm First	Do not execute until the branch or other named authority confirms the exact arrangement.
Post Start	Complete on or after 1 November, or during the first reporting cycle.

A. Before 1 November — establish control and readiness

These items give the new body a functioning decision structure, secure records, meeting arrangements and ministry support before the effective date.

Done	Task	Owner	Gate	Source / evidence
☐	Read page 1 of the approval letter at the first midweek meeting after receipt. Do not read the confidential postscript.	Coordinator	Branch Required	Approval letter p. 2
☐	Post page 1 of the approval letter on the information board after the announcement. The coordinator approves information-board content.	Coordinator	Branch Required	Approval letter p. 2; SFG 13:14
☐	Secure the confidential postscript and limit it to those authorised to use it. Do not read or post page 2.	Secretary	Branch Required	Approval letter p. 2; SFG 17:1-6
☐	Complete the Congregation Service Committee. Adamson dela Cruz and Dave Asuncion are confirmed; the service overseer remains to be confirmed.	Body of elders / circuit overseer	Operational Readiness	SFG 1:10
☐	Assign the essential congregation roles and rosters. Prioritise accounts, literature, territory, meeting oversight, public talks, A/V, attendants, field service groups and cleaning; use the organisation chart as the working register.	Body of elders	Operational Readiness	SFG 1:4, 12, 14-19; Organisation chart
☐	Prepare the new JW Hub domain and access transition. Confirm the coordinator and secretary can see the new domain during the branch transition window.	Coordinator / Secretary	Branch Required	Approval letter p. 2
☐	Obtain and review the current Instructions for Congregation Use of JW Hub (S-135). Use it for access, person	Secretary	Operational Readiness	SFG 17:4, 8, 11

Done	Task	Owner	Gate	Source / evidence
	transfers, official correspondence and record handling.			
☐	Create a secure congregation file and its required categories. Accounts; circuit overseer reports; confidential records; elders and ministerial servants; Kingdom Hall; letters of introduction; territory.	Secretary	Operational Readiness	SFG 17:1-2
☐	Update the shared Kingdom Hall Agreement (S-46). Record meeting times, use and care, each congregation's operating-expense responsibility, operating-account balance and extraordinary-expense limits.	Combined bodies of elders	Operational Readiness	SFG 13:5
☐	Publish the first month of meeting assignments and support rosters. Include chairmen, readers, A/V, attendants, talks, Life and Ministry parts and approved substitutes; verify the approved Thursday 7:15 p.m. and Saturday 7:00 p.m. times.	Coordinator / meeting overseers	Operational Readiness	SFG 4; S-5
☐	Establish field service groups and ministry support. Assign publishers, group overseers/servants and assistants; prepare territory and literature handling.	Service Committee / Service Overseer	Operational Readiness	SFG 1:15-19
☐	Prepare congregation emergency contacts and shared-hall safety procedures. Apply privacy safeguards; know the current security, incident and life-safety direction.	Body of elders / Kingdom Hall Operating Committee	Operational Readiness	SFG 11:6, 11; SFG 13:1, 13

B. Legal, charity, tax and banking — confirm the structure first

The account and accounting system are operational needs. Separate legal-entity, charity and tax registrations are conditional because the available branch letter and S-50 do not instruct this congregation to register independently.

Done	Task	Owner	Gate	Source / evidence
☐	Ask the branch Accounting/Legal function to identify the approved legal and banking structure for congregation 3814. Confirm whether the congregation uses an existing nationwide entity/registration or needs any separate local entity; obtain the exact legal name, IRD/charity identifiers and process in writing.	Secretary / Coordinator	Confirm First	SFG 1:14; Charities Register research
☐	Obtain and review the current Instructions for Congregation Accounting (S-27) and tutorial videos. Treat S-27 as the controlling accounting checklist; this project does not have a current local copy.	Coordinator / Secretary / Accounts Servant	Branch Required	SFG 1:12, 14; SFG 13:11
☐	Appoint and train the accounts servant. The secretary oversees the work; the coordinator arranges audits.	Body of elders	Operational Readiness	SFG 1:4, 12, 14
☐	Approve and minute the bank-account resolution. Use the exact branch-approved legal/account name, address, account operators and authorisations. Have the number of signers and approval controls match S-27.	Body of elders / Service Committee	Confirm First	SFG 1:14; BNZ group-account requirements
☐	Assemble the bank onboarding pack. Expect entity or registration evidence if applicable, recent	Secretary / Accounts Servant	Confirm First	BNZ group-account requirements; DIA

Done	Task	Owner	Gate	Source / evidence
	signed minutes, authorised-person identity/address verification and tax-residency information; follow the selected bank's current checklist.			customer due diligence guidance
☐	Open and verify the congregation bank account and online access. Test deposits, authorised payments, statements and handover access before relying on it; do not receive funds under an assumed entity name.	Authorised brothers	Operational Readiness	S-27 (current edition required)
☐	Set up the congregation accounting records and approved payment/donation workflow. Record opening balances, statement cycle, approvals, reports, receipts and secure retention exactly as directed by S-27.	Accounts Servant / Secretary	Operational Readiness	SFG 1:12, 14; SFG 17:2
☐	Schedule the first congregation accounts audit and future audit cycle. Record who will audit, the period covered and where the report will be filed.	Coordinator	Operational Readiness	SFG 1:12; S-27 (current edition required)
☐	Only if directed, complete the approved entity/Charities Services registration path. Use branch-approved rules and officers. Charities Services registration is voluntary generally and is not established here as a separate start condition; current applications may take up to 20 weeks.	Authorised officers	Confirm First	Charities Services registration guidance; Companies Office if incorporation is directed
☐	Only if directed, complete the correct IRD, donee-status and tax setup.	Authorised officers /	Confirm First	Inland Revenue not-for-profit IRD guidance

Done	Task	Owner	Gate	Source / evidence
	If registering with Charities Services, do not separately apply for an IRD number; Inland Revenue says it supplies one after registration. Otherwise use the route specified for the approved entity.	Accounts Servant		

C. On or shortly after 1 November — activate the congregation

These transfers and confirmations take effect when congregation 3814 begins functioning, not while the Tagalog group remains under the host congregation.

Done	Task	Owner	Gate	Source / evidence
☐	Receive letters of introduction and S-21 records from former congregations. Former secretaries send them on or shortly after 1 November.	Former secretaries / Dave Asuncion	Branch Required	Approval letter p. 2; SFG 17:10-11
☐	Receive Congregation Persons transfers in JW Hub. Reconcile every expected publisher with the proposed list and investigate omissions or duplicates.	Former secretaries / Dave Asuncion	Branch Required	Approval letter p. 2; S-135
☐	Submit S-62 recommendations for elders and ministerial servants who transfer. No S-62 is needed for the brothers assigned as coordinator and secretary.	New Congregation Service Committee	Branch Required	Approval letter p. 2

Done	Task	Owner	Gate	Source / evidence
☐	Review and confirm transferred regular pioneers. Check the introduction-letter recommendation, confirm each pioneer wishes to continue and announce favourable confirmations at the next midweek meeting.	Congregation Service Committee	Post Start	SFG 14:4
☐	Make the authorised appointment and pioneer announcements at the proper time. Do not announce prospective assignments before they are effective or confirmed under current direction.	Coordinator	Post Start	Approval letter p. 2; SFG 14:4
☐	Put the interim territory arrangement into operation. Use the boundaries submitted with S-6 until updated territory assignments arrive; create controlled territory records and assignments.	Service Overseer / Territory Servant	Branch Required	Approval letter p. 2; S-6
☐	Activate literature, periodical, workbook and shipping arrangements. Verify the M-202 request, literature handling and the S-36/Kingdom Hall Literature Group arrangement; avoid duplicate orders during the handover.	Service Overseer / Literature Servant / Secretary	Operational Readiness	S-36; M-202; SFG 1:17
☐	Begin separate S-88 attendance and S-21 publisher records for the new congregation. Use the electronic or printed method decided by the body and preserve confidentiality.	Secretary	Post Start	SFG 17:13-15

D. First month and ongoing — prove the system works

Close the launch by completing the first reports, testing routines and recording all recurring obligations.

Done	Task	Owner	Gate	Source / evidence
☐	Submit the congregation's first field service report after the end of November. Reconcile publisher reports first; the general monthly deadline in SFG is no later than the 20th.	Secretary	Branch Required	Approval letter p. 2; SFG 17:14
☐	Complete and review the first monthly congregation accounts report. Confirm statement reconciliation, approvals, target balance and filing under the current S-27.	Accounts Servant / Secretary / Body of elders	Post Start	S-27 (current edition required)
☐	Establish the new congregation's controlled information-board routine. Coordinator approval is required; post only congregation-activity information and the current cleaning schedule.	Coordinator / Secretary	Operational Readiness	SFG 13:9, 14
☐	Run the first cleaning cycle and confirm supplies and safety instructions. Coordinate with the shared-hall operating committee; post the schedule.	Cleaning Coordinator	Operational Readiness	SFG 13:8-9
☐	Confirm the congregation's participation in the shared Kingdom Hall operating arrangement. The combined bodies appoint the operating committee; record the new congregation's representative, expenses and communication route.	Combined bodies of elders	Operational Readiness	SFG 13:4-6
☐	Hold a 30-day launch review. Reconcile people, appointments, meetings, ministry, territory, literature, bank/accounting, hall use and unresolved correspondence; assign corrective actions.	Body of elders	Post Start	Project control review

Done	Task	Owner	Gate	Source / evidence
☐	Create the recurring compliance and review calendar. Include monthly reports/accounts, audits, January file review, hall/agreement reviews and—only if the approved entity is separately registered—Charities Services annual return within six months of balance date and change notifications.	Secretary / Coordinator	Post Start	SFG 17:2; Charities Services annual returns

Forms and instructions to have at hand

Reference	What it controls	Availability
Approval letter AUS2824311_1	Controls the official identity, effective date and transition instructions.	Local original: 27-AUS2824311_1.pdf
S-27	Congregation accounting, bank/payment controls, reports, target balance and audits.	Current copy still needs to be obtained from JW Docs.
S-135	JW Hub access, person records and electronic congregation workflow.	Current copy still needs to be obtained from JW Docs.
S-46	Shared Kingdom Hall decisions and financial/use arrangements.	Use/update the hall's current agreement; blank/current copy not found locally.
S-42	Kingdom Hall Operating Committee accounting.	Relevant to the shared-hall committee; current copy not found locally.
S-283 / S-288 / S-287	Life safety, security plan and Kingdom Hall internet service.	Review current versions with the operating committee.
S-21 / S-88 / S-62	Publisher records, meeting attendance and appointed-brother recommendations.	Use via current JW Hub/branch workflow.

New Zealand official references

These are decision support for a structure approved by the branch—not authority to create a separate entity independently.

- Charities Services — About the Charities Register — Confirms registration is voluntary and describes public information on the register.
- Charities Services — Online registration application — Lists the entity, rules, officers, activities and documents required if separate registration is directed.
- Charities Services — Register search and processing notice — Current service notice says registration applications may take up to 20 weeks.
- Charities Services — Annual returns — Registered charities file an annual return within six months after balance date.
- Inland Revenue — IRD number for a not-for-profit — Explains entity sequencing and that intended Charities Services applicants should not separately apply for an IRD number.
- Companies Office — Charitable Trusts Register — Incorporation path only if that legal structure is directed.
- BNZ — Opening an account for a group or society — Illustrates current bank evidence, minutes, key-person ID and tax-residency requirements; use the selected bank's own checklist.
- DIA — AML/CFT customer due diligence — Explains why banks identify the entity, beneficial owners/controllers and people acting for it.
- Christian Congregation of Jehovah's Witnesses of New Zealand — CC36365 — Public evidence that a nationwide entity is registered; it does not by itself establish the legal arrangement for congregation 3814.

Research conclusion: Charities Services says registration is voluntary. Public-register research located nationwide Jehovah's Witnesses charitable entities, but did not establish that congregation 3814 must register separately. Therefore the safe first action is written confirmation from the branch Accounting/Legal function of the correct entity, IRD, charity and bank arrangement.

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